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Introduction to Art

The earth and all of its beauty is the first source of art to which the human is exposed. It is often the first source which inspires one to create art for himself. The world is filled with a special kind of beauty that is achieved by the interaction of color, line and form. Think of the colors of the sunset, the lines of the mountains, the shapes formed by canyons and buttes.

We do not have to visit a museum to find art. Not only do we see it in the natural landscape. We see it in buildings, landscapes and many other things that are the creation of the human mind. Consider the Milwaukee Art Museum. Because verbal and analytical thinking have always dominated human life in educational settings, a greater emphasis typically has been placed on those aspects. Therefore, it is hard to imagine that there might be other ways to translate experiences – ones outside the verbal realm. Sometimes it is hard to recognize that we can benefit from a visual perceptual language such as the pictorial arts – to act as a parallel to verbal analytical thought processes. But drawings have meaning that goes beyond the power of words.

Drawings and images allow us to express our thoughts and to make the chaos of our sensory impressions comprehensible. Learning to draw is not a skill useful to only a few people. By learning to draw, one can actually learn to see differently. Perceptual skills, requirements for the execution of art, are enhanced by training – just as verbal analytical skills develop through education. Learning to draw or observe effectively trains the visual system just as reading and writing efficiently train the verbal system. This is not to say that one system is better than the other. We need both; they work hand in hand to release human creativity and capacities.

Books offer us pleasure, distraction and relaxation. But before we can enjoy those benefits, we must learn the mechanics of reading. Again, there is a parallel that exists between reading and drawing, painting and sculpture. There is a body of knowledge in each domain of art as there is with reading and it must be learned to prepare the child with the skills and tools for realizing the enhanced pleasure and appreciation that can be found from expressing himself in art. To become an artist in any sphere, a person must prepare himself with the basic foundation of knowledge, of his chosen artistic expression.

Once the children learn the basic skills, they will be equipped to explore the subject according to their own delights and their own imaginations. Even though we as Montessori teachers are not always artists, there are compelling reasons for presenting the child with art opportunities. Art is an essential part of the common core of knowledge. It constitutes a universal language.

All peoples express themselves through art of some kind. The child comes into contact with his own heritage and culture through art. Another reason, is that engaging in art helps the child develop and aesthetic perception and appreciation through multi-sensory experiences. Plus, practice with art materials sharpen sensory awareness in a way that looking at an object simply cannot do. For example, you may have a color in the mind's eye, but until one tries to mix it for oneself, you may not understand its precise

and exact properties. Think about the color of a cherry and then think of the limited palette of colors in a paint set. How does one use those colors to come up with cherry-red? A cherry is not pure red – it has other hues mixed in. So, through visual analysis and physical color mixing, the child can discover that there are blues in the actual red of a cherry.

From a book called “The Zen of Seeing”, Frederick Franck tells us, “I have learned that what I have not drawn, I have not really seen. One of the best ways to learn is to observe and one of the best ways to observe is to draw.”

Other benefits of presenting art to the children is that again, they have to learn to make a choice. They have to be patient. They have to discriminate visually. They have to find solutions and integrate thoughts into visual forms. And so we have another opportunity to develop human potential. We have to remember that our goal is not to produce artists. And we have not been unsuccessful if the child fails to become a professional artist. Our goal is to provide the child with an avenue for self-expression. Not all artistic talent is born and not all visual sensitivity is innate. They are created by a mixture of exposure and encouragement. This we can provide in the Montessori class.

Who Teaches the Art and Building-Block Lessons

Now that we appreciate the importance of providing art experience to the child, two questions loom before us. The first is, who presents the art in a Montessori classroom? The second is, how do we proceed?

First, without equivocation, **it is the Montessori teacher himself who presents the art** lessons to the children within the confines of her own class. Here are the reasons why.

Art lessons can be given in a flexible fluid manner, just as are the lessons in biology, geography, history and so on. In this way, the child is not pulled out of the classroom to accommodate the schedule of an outside teacher – thereby interrupting the work of the child. But instead, the child can have art lessons whenever the interest spontaneously arises. By presenting art in this fashion, the basic Montessori tenet of protecting the child's work period is also satisfied. Also, when the teacher gives an art lessons, the child is left with the impression that everyone can make art! Even me! It does not require a specialist. A teacher does not need to be an expert on art; all he need know is the basic elements that need to be presented, how to present them and the tools and media involved per each element of art. Then there must be practice. Another reasons for presenting art directly in the classroom is that when there is art in the classroom, it becomes a dynamic exciting place to be; children want to be involved. Furthermore, they become inspired by seeing the work of others. This exposure motivates their own native interest and artistic capacities. When art happens outside the classroom, an opportunity for inspiration is denied to the other children.

Secondly, how we proceed; we give the basic art elements. If we are giving concepts and skills for later manipulation by the children, we must present them with **building-block lessons of art. These are lessons on line, texture, color, shape or form, composition and perspective.** When they understand the elements of art, they will have the essential components involved in creating a piece of art in some medium. And then,

they will be able to manipulate ideas in their imaginations and devise original and unique expressions of who they are.

It is just as Dr. Montessori said in “Discovery of the Child”, when she said, “We do not teach drawing by drawing, however, but by providing the opportunity to prepare the instruments of expression. This, I consider to be a real aid to free drawing.” One of the instruments of expression is a clear understanding of the elements of art. This is a completely different approach than introducing children to individual art projects such as paper-making, which by its very nature is limited in scope. When children know and understand the elemental aspects of a given art form or medium, they can extrapolate from their knowledge and be set free to truly create.

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The Art Space and the Prepared Environment

We are familiar with the idea of the prepared environment. It is a fertile ground for creativity but it must be provided for carefully and thoughtfully. It must have the materials for self-expression and creative opportunities. So, our art environment has to provide both the tools for different media and the space the child needs for artistic expression. To compliment the tools, we have to show how to use the tools.

The elementary classroom should be beautiful, attractive and clean. Walking into a beautiful environment has an impact on the aesthetic appreciation of the children. Furthermore, if you have a beautiful, clean environment, the children will take care of it. If it is dirty and disorganized, it will mean nothing to the child to add to the clutter and disorder.

So, there is a psychological aspect to consider when preparing the environment. Art areas, in particular, at some point become a messy chaos by natural course. Within the classroom, one should provide beautiful art objects that inspire the child to draw. Express your own personal tastes in the classroom. Containers used to hold rubber-bands and other materials can be housed in beautiful inspiring containers.

We want to inspire the child by making a beautiful environment; they will then respect it. One has to take special care to set up and maintain an art area since they tend to become messy. This means one should consider carefully the amount of space available. Just because one has a small classroom does not mean you cannot do art in it. But think it through carefully in order to succeed. It is essential that shelves be ordered and materials organized to easily find what is needed. As a part of this organization, develop routines for use of the materials so it will remain in good condition and can remain ordered and clean.

It will be the routines that are set up that will aid the success in teaching art. But there must be a process that allows the child to be accountable as well. One must follow through on expectations laid down. Provide good quality brushes and they are expensive. Children have the tendency to leave the brush bristle-down in water – which destroys the bristles. They have the tendency to leave paint in the brush, also destroying it. But if there is a routine whereby each time a brush is used, the cleaning is checked before putting materials away, then everyone will know the brushes are cared for and this routine establishes a trend for all in the classroom.

The material on the shelf should be set up so the child can work independently. Think the placement through so the child does not have to rely on an adult to get them. Limit the choices on the shelves because if it is cluttered, it becomes hard to find what is needed, physically and psychologically. Also, consider where the artwork will be stored while it is drying and when it is finished and not yet taken home.

Tools and Materials

Before introducing tools and materials, try them out to know what effects they can bring to the art. Use good quality materials. It does not have to be the most expensive but should not be the cheapest either. When you provide good materials for the child, they will come to appreciate it, take care of the materials and the materials will last a longer time. Good materials help produce a better finished product which aids the child's chances for success and satisfaction.

Every piece of material that goes onto the shelf must be carefully presented to the children. One cannot assume they know how to use the different media. Sometimes, they will take a tool and use it in a way it is not intended – to achieve a certain effect. But if you observe what they are doing, then you can introduce them to a proper tool that will yield the same effect.

Paints

Tempera

Tempera paints come in two forms: powdered and liquid. Liquid is easier to work with because one does not need to mix as with powdered. Cheap tempera paint is not worth buying. What makes a paint worth buying is the amount of pigment dissolved in its medium. Children measure their abilities by the results they get so this is important. This paint stains clothes so have them wear smocks.

A good tempera will be opaque when it comes out of the jar but can be thinned if too thick. So one can control the degree of transparency. Another nice feature of tempera is that one can rework a painting after it is dry – adding another layer as needs be, and it won't muddy the colors.

Because tempera is cheaper than most other paints, it is good for exploration for the children.

Water-Color

These come in tubes, trays and even in concentrated liquid forms. Again, cheap water-colors are a waste of money. Water color is nice because when it dries in the palette, it is not wasted. It can be rewetted and used again. The same applies when making a painting with water-colors. He can rewet the painting and reapply colors.

Gouache

This is a wonderful paint for the 9-12 age children. Why? One can have children paint with gouache and they take colored pencil and work on top of the paint. It is extremely expensive. It is more opaque than water-color, having a high proportion of pigment.

Acrylic

This is a plastic paint and it comes in tubes and jars. It provides an intense color and it is creamy and easy to work with. What one should know is there are two kinds: transparent and opaque. Acrylic paint cannot be rewet but once they dry – and they dry quickly – one can paint over them. Acrylic is very good for bisqued pottery. But if putting acrylic on bisqued pottery, first give it a layer of gesso because clay is porous and it will suck up all the expensive acrylic. A tip: buy a quart of latex paint at the hardware store instead of buying gesso at the art store.

Oil

One needs toxic cleaners and these are difficult to use.

Brushes

You want to have a selection of brushes. One needs different tips for different effects. One should also have different sizes. If brushes are ruined, don't throw them away but save the from gross work such as charts and murals.

Separate brushes used for acrylic and those used for water-color. Water-color brushes are soft and flexible. Acrylic brushes are more firm since they must withstand a certain pressure in use. One can also use acrylic brushes for tempera paint as well.

It is a good idea to color-code brushes. Blue are water-color, for example. Try finding an art catalog since they usually have pages for tips and sizes of brushes that can be used as a resource for planning.

Show the child a Windsor-Newton video on paint. Windsor-Newton is a British company and the video shows how paints and brushes are made, how people used to mix their own paints and is educational.

Use unscented natural soap to clean brushes occasionally. Spend more on brushes than paint, generally speaking.

Drawing Material

Pastels are made from finely ground pigments in a base of chalk or clay. They are nice since one can get a good spectrum of color. They come in hard or soft variety. Soft is easy to work with because it provides good color and instant color; it is soft and messy though. After children use soft pastels, one must spray a fixative – such as hair-spray – preventing smearing of color upon touch.

The hard pastels provide a harder edge and take more effort to get pigment onto the paper. It provides a nice vibrant color though. There is also Nupastel – which is a combination of soft and hard.

There is also oil pastels. These are pigments that is mixed with fat or wax. They are thicker and harder but don't blend as well among colors. They do not require a fixative later on, however.

Conte Crayons

These come in blacks and whites, grays and skin colors. They give a softness and warmth to a drawing. They are like pastels but a little harder and oilier.

Colored Inks

These can be used in paintings as well as with calligraphy. They give a nice glossy finished when they dry.

Graphite Pencils

These are used just for drawing and come in sets. They range in degrees of hardness.

Charcoal Pencils

These are better than charcoal since they don't break as easily and are less messy. They come in white as well as black. White is good for working on dark-colored paper.

Special Colored Pencils

Prismacolor is an excellent brand but are expensive. What makes them nice is there is a lot of pigment for the base they are in. They produce rich colors. Where you have expensive pencils on the shelf, one needs to give lessons on how to sharpen pencils since an expensive pencil can disappear quickly. Be sure to insist on manual sharpeners – not automatic or rotary.

Erasers

One needs an art eraser; one unwraps them. Gum eraser and pink eraser.

Have a variety.

Paper

Paper is important in an elementary class. Have a variety of sizes, colors and grades. One needs tissue paper, wrapping paper, construction paper, card-stock in various colors, fade-less paper, origami paper, newsprint, water-color paper, special paper for print-making and something called Bristol-board.

Make sure the child uses the right paper for the right use and effect. If doing a collage, use a paper that is substantial. If doing water-colors, use water-color paper.

Use acid-free paper when possible.

Sculpture

One needs earthen clay. If there is no kiln to fire projects in, use a store that will fire for you at a price. One can find ceramic art studios that will fire for a fee as well. To work with earthen clay is very satisfying for child. There are 25 pound sacks of clay for order. If it dries out just put water in it.

Clay is a very forgiving medium. One can make mistakes and clay and resurrect the piece. It is great for exploration. One needs to have specific sculpting tools – a variety of them. We want them to get the desired effect without frustration.

One can buy kits of sculpting tools. Dental tools are good for this – for eyebrows for example. There is a clay called Sculpy; this can be molded and formed and baked in the oven. It is not as satisfying to work with but comes in different colors or just white. The pink can be painted with acrylics. After it is baked, it is a bit brittle – not as satisfying as earthen clay.

There is another clay called Fimo. However, it is very hard to work with. It must be worked and worked and take lots of strength and time. Children tend to not have this much patience but it is good for making jewelry.

Print-Making Materials

Materials that can be used are stamps, sponges, linoleum (which is hard to work with but recently there is something called Softoleum which is improved). Styrofoam is also something that can be used.

Have special paint for print-making, special print-paper – which is softer and absorbs the ink well. One needs a roller of brayer, an ink-plate which is used to work colors onto, under the paper. One needs a baren which is used to rub color onto the medium. There should be linoleum cutters. There should be a variety of sizes and points that attach to a handle used for linoleum.

Miscellaneous Supplies

Have different kinds and colors of glues. 5-minute epoxy, white glue, Yes glue (wonderful because it dries quickly and holds securely, plus is used with many materials). Have good scissors that cut well, with different edges and sizes – for both right and left handed students.

Have protective clothing such as smocks. One needs a selection of different art prints – especially those out of a book. You want the child to go through a group of prints and select, reordering prints conveniently and with different sizes. Have them grouped so the children can find what they need by: artist, period of history, cultural elements such as masks or buildings, elements of art (color, line, etc.) and so on.

Have a shellac as well.

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Points About Presenting the Material

Prepare the working space by **protecting the space** with butcher or newspaper. Protect the child with smocks and goggles as needs be. Take them to the shelf and show them where the material is kept – and where they expect to see it when they are finished and condition one expects it to be in.

Typically, for an art presentation certain things are needed on the table. A container of water, paper towels and something in which to put paint are needed. Older children can use almost any plate or palette to hold paint but for 6 year olds, they need candle bases which are heavy and don't tip over.

For children who are using brushes, we don't want them to lay them on the table. Provide them a chopstick holder on which to lay the brush.

Clean-up

Always **show the child how to clean up**. This is where expectations are set. One secret for this is to **allow enough time** so the child can clean up satisfactorily. Doing art in the afternoon, one may need to begin earlier than those earlier in the day.

Present the cleaning of brush techniques, done afterward but also between use of different colors. This is when one teaches the respect and proper use of the brush; don't crunch bristles, don't leave it in the water indefinitely, don't leave pigment on the brush – and show them how to rest the brush on the chopstick holder. Children can waste paint when they don't use brushes properly.

Show the child how to put just a bit of paint onto the palette -especially if its acrylic since much comes out with little effort.

Presentation

When presenting the **art elements, focus on one element at a time**. In the beginning, encourages the beginners. They children will come up with their own ideas and sometimes cannot translate the idea onto the page. So focus on one idea; "Look how many different kinds of lines there are!" This prevents frustration. Never judge the child's work and never correct a beginner's work. We want the child to build confidence so let them derive pleasure and success from one aspect at a time. Don't be excessively complimentary. Say, "I can see you've been working on texture!" These state appreciation in an objective response without losing sincerity.

Take the children to museums to see various types of art and media. Relate what is happening in the classroom with art in the outside world.

Be **careful about hanging children's art** in the classroom. Rule of thumb is

not to do it since if we hang one, we must hang all. The classroom will begin to look cluttered. Hang pieces temporarily but don't do it indiscriminately.

If there is a technique beyond one's capacity to teach, have a **guest lecturer** come in who can show the children something new but don't let this lead into having an art teacher.

Epilogue

Set expectations diligently and carefully. If children abuse their art materials, take the privilege of doing art away for a time if that child is capable but simply not conforming. Allow them show you in a well-defined way when they have gained the respect for the materials and are ready to use them again.

Have many good art books in the classroom for exploration.

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Art Elements and Media

Present each element is isolation. At the same time presenting an element, present a particular medium appropriate to the element. The steps for introducing an element are:

- tell the children the name of the element presented (giving the name it helps him focus on what things will look like)
- definition or description of the element in an introductory exercise
- introduce materials
- give child a change to experiment with element and the medium
- during the experience, verbally analyze the children's work ("Here's a curved line! It has a neat effect.")
- after child has some experience, allow the child to sort through prints and find pieces of art where the element is visible.

This experimental art can be made into booklets: "My Book of Lines." The five basic elements are:

- line
- texture
- shape or form
- color
- value

We speak of composition and perspective but these are made from the five constituent elements.

Lines / Tempera

Give the name. The element of lines begins with a dot and goes off in any directions. There can be straight, curved, broken, thick or thin, dark or light lines. One can make lines with a pen, charcoal or chalk, or with a pencil. Some lines are only implied and not actual.

From lines, one can **derive shading by hatching and cross-hatching**. They can be used for perspective, contour and shape as well. The materials used for introducing lines will be **just one color of paint**. It is dramatic if one uses black on white or white on black. In time, take up other colors of paints and backgrounds.

It is good to **use tempera** since it is cheaper and easier to work with generally speaking.

As one introduces lines, also mention **how to hold the brush**. A brush can be held in several ways. It can be held close to the bristle, like a pencil. It can be held at the middle or end as well. Show the child different effect achieved by different grips of the brush.

Point out that **how one uses the arm has an effect** on how lines appear. Using only the fingers achieves a certain effect while using wrist also makes another effect. Lower arm and the entire arm also brings a certain effect. We want them to know there is movement in creating art and it's important to control that movement for effect. Encourage their exploration with difference effects and types of lines.

Sit down and **analyze the kinds of lines they've made** to make them aware of them. Relate the work also to geometry when appropriate. Have them color in some of the spaces created by the lines; then they become aware the lines create shape and composition.

Since we want to extend their work with lines, **have them go outside and look at different kinds of weather** and then take a piece of Bristol board, section it off and let them create lines based on different kinds of weather: sandstorm, earthquake, fog, snow, rain and so on. This is experimental but they gain experience that helps them remember. Another thing to do is let the child **make different lines while listening to different kinds of music**. This provides another means of generating expression and experience.

Texture

Texture is the look or feel of a piece. We know every surface has a texture of some kind. The challenge in drawing is to depict the texture of a surface. Sometimes it is smooth, shiny, rough, dull or it has a nap (where touching a certain direction makes a different appearance).

There are certain techniques used to depict certain textures. One can use certain brushwork. One such technique is called *impasto*; Van Gogh used this. Get a piece of Bristol board and section it off.

Collect different objects from the environment of varying textures. Pine cones, rocks, leaves, yarn are useful. Encourage the child to feel these different textures. Then ask them to depict the different textures on one of the sections of the Bristol board.

Begin with one color initially and build up to using multiple colors. Have the children cut the sections from the Bristol board, matching the picture of the texture to the item that they have modeled. It can be fun to let them guess the textures intended by each other. Once cut into pieces, the work can be put into booklets. Corals, coconuts, Yucca leaf, shark's teeth – all these are interesting. This gives one an idea of the child's interest as well. It provides opportunities for comparison of adjectives as well – and any other types of classroom experiences they've had.

Rubbings involve a piece of paper laid over a rock of leaf and so on, using large crayons to draw over the paper so that the image is left on the paper. This is another good exercise with texture. Textures are harder to see. Let them examine prints after they've had some substantial experience with their own ideas of texture. Van Gogh's "Starry Night" is a fine example, as is "Arnoldfini" by Jan Van Eick.

Color

We know that color is sunlight that goes through a prism and is broken down into its constituent parts. Those parts are the visible color spectrum. When speaking about color, have books available so they can discover more about the theory of color. Children are surprised to find there are seven colors in a rainbow – not just six.

Another interesting thing to discover is the history of color. The first paintings had a very reduced palette: black, charcoal, gray and ochre (colored red earth). All of these colors were from cave paintings.

Little by little the color palette used developed. What was interesting for those first painters is what they used to apply the paint: hollow bones for blowing the color on or their fingers used to smear it on. Find books that talk about the history of colors. Ultra-marine is one color to look into in the context of 14th century Flemish painters depicting the Madonna.

Do color-mixing exercises. This is exciting for them – even ones that have had it in primary. Begin with the primary colors and let them make discoveries on their own. Get pieces of Bristol board and begin with the three primary colors and say, "We're going to mix these together and see what we get." Give them a palette tray that allows the three colors as well as areas for mixing. Let them know they should use equal amounts of each paint to be mixed together.

It is with this activity that one should establish and reinforce the importance of cleaning the brush very well.

After they know about color mixing, have them mix their colors in a palette and paint each of their six colors into sections of Bristol boards and get a circle inset from the geometry cabinet. Once the paint is dry, have them cut out circles for each of their six colors, starting by placing each of the three primary colors into a triangle on another surface. Then cut out the secondary circles and place them in the location relative to their primary color origins.

Now we can introduce to them a color-wheel since they've had some experience. Make sure they know it is used as a painter's reference and there is a relationship between colors. This is one reason we put them in a circle in early explorations. If they have forgotten the names "primary" and "secondary", reinforce these terms. Introduce them to the terms complimentary colors; these always appear opposite each other on the color wheel and they always appear harmonic together and painters make use of this fact. The children can then make conscious choices based on this

information.

The child sees many colors in nature and this should be pointed out. Holly is green and red. Blue and orange is seen in the Bird of Paradise. These are all naturally occurring complimentary colors.

If you have the children mix complimentary colors together, they will discover that one gets brown every time – different shades of brown. Once they've had some experience in making different colors, have them do an extended color wheel, where they include **tertiary colors** – adjacent colors on the wheel.

Introduce them to artists who have made use of complimentary colors.

Other discoveries include that black occurs when all colors are absorbed and white comes when no colors are absorbed. They can investigate mood in color. Speak to them about our language in this context: “I feel blue. I saw red in my anger!” When they come up with colors on the sectioned off Bristol board, make sure they make no happy face to show mood – emphasize they should only use color. Ask them what the color of the taste of a pickle would be. Appeal to all the senses in stimulating their exploration.

Remember to **analyze the work** so they consciously become aware of what made the mood apparent in the work.

One aid to the children in remembering the colors of the rainbow is the name Roy G. Biv – which is an acronym for red, orange, yellow, green, blue indigo, violet. These colors appear in that order on color wheels and are used as is or in various mixes.

Shades / Tints

Introduce **shades and tints**. These give one a certain tone in a painting – a feel in the painting. Begin with one primary color. If making a shade – add black to it. If making a tint – add white to it. Use strips of paper, sectioned off and have them create grades, beginning with the primary color, progressing by increasing black/white for each successive section. This is not an easy exercise, so help them achieve a gradual gradation of shade/tint. They can make strips for primary, secondary and tertiary colors and combine them later in some format.

Once they know about tints and shades and they start doing their own paintings, encourage them to use tints and shades for effect.

Tone

Tone has to do with the quality of the impression an artist achieves. It is achieved by the effects of light on the surface. It can be gentle or harsh. They achieve

tone using tints.

In general, value, tone and shade combine to create an overall impression. Go through art prints analyzing how tone, shade and tint are used.

Value / Contrast

Value is the intensity of color. Once achieves better value when there is more pigment per bonding material. Painters show value through contrast. Ask the child to envision a scene where everyone is dressed in white – walls are white – and in walks a woman in a bright red dress and bright red hat. This is an example of value in an image.

Contrast also help make up the tone of a piece of work. So tone is created by the effect one color has on another. White room – red lady, for example.

Rembrandt provides fine examples of using light for effect. Light and Dark is expressed in a word – chiaroscuro – an Italian word used by their artists to sum up the use of this effect.

Colors can be warm or cool. This is important when you buy colors for the classroom. Any hue can be made cool by adding white. Make colors warm by adding reds. When doing warm and cool colors, do a color-mixing exercise. Have them go through prints looking for warm and cool colors.

Shape

Shape is an element that **utilizes a dot or a circle, a straight line, curved line or angled line** – or a dot that is filled in. One makes shapes with lines – but the basic constituents of shape is the list above.

A medium to use is pencil. Markers can be used to introduce shape to a limited extent. Give them Bristol board and ask them to do a composition using just one of the five elements.

Or, have them create 6 dots, 3 curvy lines, 2 straight – and so on – some **formula dictated to them** – and see where they take it. Have them use certain combinations for exploration. Then they can fill in certain shapes that have been created.

Make them consciously aware of the five constituents of shape and how useful they can be. Have them fill in the shapes with colors to accentuate the effect they have achieved.

Play music and have them use the five basic – any one – to express what they hear. As we did with texture, use emotion and other perceptual phenomenon to experiment with shape. The five basic constituents of shape can be related to certain bodies of art – such as Aborigine art.

Have a grid piece of paper and ask them to **copy the shapes** appearing in the top row. They can move on with practice to recognizable objects like a button. Or, ask them to copy geometrical shapes – which requires them to track the lines carefully.

When working with shapes, give them opportunities for working with **contour drawings**. For example, they look at their hand and begin to draw – never taking their eyes off of their hands. They **track every line without looking at the page**, always looking at the hand. The eye is the pencil; this uses a certain aspect of the brain.

Another activity is to give them a Picasso, “Portrait of Igor Stravinsky”, for example. Turn it upside down and **look at the relationships between lines**; don't look at it as a man sitting in the chair. On white paper, have them recreate it – working upside down. Only look at lines in relationship; the result may be better than if the child is asked to draw a man in a chair. See Appendix for this example.

With shape we also speak of **negative and positive shapes**. We consider what shapes look like on the rest of the paper. Get a large piece of paper. Use a starfish or hand; have them arrange it on the paper in a way that is attractive. Have them pencil around it and have them paint the background. Painting the background is painting the negative space. The starfish or hand is the positive space on the image. Cutouts can be done in the same effect – laying them on a background and pasting them on. Offer books about positive and negative space. Here we are reversing the human point of attention – manipulating the process of focus to achieve an effect.

Epilogue

The book “Drawing on the Right Side of the Brain”, by Betty Edwards, is an excellent resource in the classroom.

February 25, 2005

Perspective

Perspective is a Western technique for presenting depth that appears in a painting. We know a painting is two-dimensional but there are techniques to create the illusion of depth. Perspective drawing is best done with 9-12 children; take them outside to look at the depth in nature around them first. If there are mountains in the background, they will see the mountains in the far distance are lighter in hue than those in the foreground. If you look down a road, one will see the parallel lines of the street's side will seem to converge. Look at things like fences over a distance and see how they seem to become smaller.

Things that are far away are not in focus and are smaller. Point these things out to the children in the real environment around them. Go through the prints in the classroom and identify perspective for the children.

There are **two kinds of perspective. One is atmospheric and the other is linear.**

Atmospheric perspective uses the lighter images in the background and ones that are less in focus. With the children let them experience atmospheric perspective by making paintings of mountains. Take a piece of paper and make 3-4 levels of zig-zag lines. With water-colors, have them start in the sky with a wash of blue. Then, in the most distance layer of mountains, make the blue a little darker. Continue to have hues get darker as one approaches the foreground. Introduce purples in the hues – or different shades of blue. The **gradation needs to be gradual to create the effect of perspective.**

Linear perspective involves a system of lines that converge at vanishing points. Those places in the distance, usually the horizon – the objects in the distance seem to disappear. The lines are diagonals and the effect is based on the principle that two parallel lines seem to come together as one looks further into the distance and the seem to meet at the furthest distance.

When using this technique with the children, it helps determine the scale of objects; those in the distance are proportionately smaller than those in the foreground. If the child has already had shading activities with you, this also helps them give dimension to their work and will understand the desired effect.

They can do a little activity with linear perspective. Make a horizontal horizon line, adding two vanishing points anywhere; this is a two-point vanishing point. Draw a partial perpendicular line above and label the top point 'tc' for top corner. Draw a straight line from each vanishing point to the top corner. Now draw a straight line from the bottom point of the parallel line to each vanishing point. Now draw parallel lines to the perpendicular line connecting the two straight lines, shading in the enclosed area created. Now, one could convert the image into a row of buildings, adding windows or whatever else one might imagine.

There is also a one-point vanishing point exercise. Begin with a horizon line and place one vanishing point on the line. Strike a perpendicular line above the horizon to one side of the vanishing point. Strike another below the horizon line, pretty much

anywhere. Strike a third line that intersects the horizon line itself. Label the top corner of all three perpendicular lines 'tc'. Making a rectangle or a square using the perpendicular line as one of the sides. Now draw straight lines from each top corner to the vanishing point. The bottom of each perpendicular line is then connected with a straight line to the vanishing point. Connect the vanishing point to each of the squares drawn to a third corner of each square, creating prism image for each square. Now strike a parallel line to the first perpendicular line for each of the squares. Draw another parallel line to the horizon, for each square, which again reinforces the idea of prism – extending from the distance horizon.

There are developments in art across the centuries. In the 14th century, perspective was not quite ripe. Brunelleschi (around 1500) was the fellow who solidified the use of perspective. The Flemish Renaissance came before him and one can see how detail in the distance is too large – indicating they did not quite have perspective correct.

Horizon Lines

Show pictures of use of perspective to the children before giving them something to do. They need to understand horizon lines which are used to draw the observer's eye to a certain point – it controls the eye. It can be found in three places in a painting: the lower part (when very low it provides a lofty and airy effect), in the middle (which provides balance to the painting), the higher part (which provides an earthy and substantial feel to the painting).

February 25, 2005

Composition

When introducing composition, collage is the best means. Composition is the arrangement of art elements in a piece of work. Composition is essential to a piece while begin invisible. It is an organizing principle of the painting or drawing. By the way one puts elements together, one can see rhythm, balance, variety, direction and motion in a piece of work.

Composition is another tricky thing for children to understand; this is why collage is so helpful. Before beginning, get out prints and examine them for things like balance, rhythm, movement, variety and direction. Have a box of pieces of paper of all weights, colors and shapes; this can be built from scraps of paper saved over time. The scraps can be torn or cut. **It is dramatic to begin in black and white.** This is useful in many contexts.

They take papers of different shapes and qualities and create a prototype-layout. Have them move the papers around the surface before pasting. Ask them about balance as one explores different layouts – don't let them rush into pasting things down. "Let's stand back and look at it carefully." This gets them to begin to analyze what the effect of the layout is. Typically, they come up with asymmetrical collages. We also want them to have experience with symmetrical collages; for this fold the base-paper in half, creating a mid-line. We want symmetry in shape, color and placement – and often this is difficult for children. Doing faces around the mid-line is interesting. Tearing is often interesting but is still does symmetrically.

Another activity for composition is to take a copy of a Picasso print and tear it into different bits. Let the children position those bits on a piece of paper and then compare it to the original. Have a discussion about it. Another kind of mosaic can be made using grains, in a manner after Pointalism. Use 'yes' glue. Don't forget to look at buildings when speaking about composition: Romanesque, Gothic, Modern – and so on.

February 25, 2005

Different Techniques with Different Media

When the children begin working with different paints, let them know the paints that can be used so they can make conscious choices. Also, let them know the different qualities of each paint. A plastic acrylic will yield only a certain effect.

When working with acrylic, again section off the page (or mask it off). On one side, the child could use tempera and on the other side acrylic. Remember to emphasize that special brushes are used for acrylic and tempera – which is different than that used with water-color. Stress this again and again since they will naturally forget this.

With the two different kinds of paints, show them techniques. One is to apply color with a sponge. Another is stippling, a certain effect, such as lots of leaves on a tree. One needs a hard stiff brush for this – stabbing the page, in effect, with the brush. One could also make a swatch of color and then use a nail or bottle cap or other items, used to make an image from removing the paint in the swatch.

Also, one could take a piece of paper, coloring it arbitrarily and randomly with pastel oil color – the whole surface – the more colors, the more interesting. Then cover all of the color with black Indian ink, letting it dry. Then, scratch a design away from the black ink with a nail or sculpture tool – leaving the color behind it. The ink comes off in a layer, leaving the colored-in image that has been scratched off.

Water-Color Technique

Stress that one does not need lots of paint. They are called water-color because we are focusing on how water is used with paint. Reiterate the point about using the correct brushes; make sure brushes are marked clearly.

One can use sponge-brushes, Chinese Calligraphy brushes, Q-tips, straws, table salt and plastic wrap, many types of material, can be used to apply water-color in various techniques.

Section off the paper for an activity. Paint one of the sections with water-color, making it a solid. Take a clean, dry brush, sponge or paper towel, and lift color off of the page. They will see different effects using different materials. Don't let the paper dry out before the lifting takes place.

Another technique called wet-into-wet begins by wetting the paper with a sponge-brush. Make streaks of color, watching how the water-color fuses into the paper. Also, you could have a wet piece of paper and cover it with a solid color; take another color and make streaks through the solid color. Another idea is to sprinkle water onto a painted solid color – seeing what happens. The same can be done with table or rock salt. Another thing to do is to paint a solid area. Then, put Indian ink around the edges – using a straw to blow the ink across the solid color to create shapes and streaks with the ink. Another material to put atop water-color is rubbing alcohol.

One techniques are introduced, help the children come up with subject matter. Thing in nature are always good choices. A lesson in biology, succulent fruits, for example can become subjects.

When children begin to make compositions on their own, talk to them about what they will paint. Their repertoire needs to be varied – not just horses an dogs all the time. At some point introduce wash, using colored-pencils to highlight the wash.

Speak to them about technique in relation to subject matter. This enters into the idea of application of technique – and on what basis one makes various choices.

Epilogue

A good resource book in the classroom for technique and its application is called “Painting Nature with Pen and Ink with Water-Color.” Remember that children can always make booklets from their work; a collection of techniques is a good way to build experience that is memorized and used for future reference.

Have artifacts in the classroom that act as inspiration to the children.

February 25, 2005

Drawing

Children naturally like to draw. It is one of the most expressive media in art. It seems to provide a direct outward root from the child's inner-self. We want the primary child to do as much drawing as possible; when they come to the elementary, they are used to drawing their own figures. Children should never trace. They should never be given printed papers to color-in. Those two activities are counter-productive with respect to children actually drawing for themselves.

Another thing about drawing which should never be done – never use felt pens to draw. When they are used, there is no finesse developed in the hand. A felt pen provides a dark solid line with just a stroke, with no capacity for providing a graded surface. They can be used for drawing certain lines, posters and so on – but not for drawing, per se.

Colored Pencils

Just as with all other tools, there are techniques to be learned. Encourage experimentation. One of the experiments is to have the child grade from, light to dark or vice versa. The can mark off a section of paper – making shapes in each of the sections that are graded – each figure is graded. If the primary teacher has helped and stressed grading, this is much easier.

Experiment with blending of colors. Use two colors, adding a swatch of each with an overlap between them; section off the paper to have a series of such experimental mixing. There is also a stylus available that acts as a blending tool, kind of mashing the pigments together.

Burnishing is another technique to be covered in the classroom. Burnish by taking a paper-towel and rubbing the top of a colored surface – providing a patina. It is interesting to use different colors on different types and colors of paper.

Frottage is another technique using colored pencil. Under a piece of paper, place a leaf or solid object. One rubs the pencil color onto the paper so that the image of the leaf (object) comes out on the paper. Frottage can be done on different textures of paper, even without an object underneath, where the paper provides the texture.

Hatching is another technique. This is drawing parallel lines densely to provide shading or texture. Adding a second perpendicular hatching is referred to as cross-hatching. The closer the lines, the more the effect becomes shading. Shading can be experimented with in drawing fruit.

Show the children how to shade a geometric shape. We want to apply the techniques now. When beginning to shade, draw objects such as a sphere. Begin with pencils, progressing to pastels and chalks. Often time when shading, we use a Q-tip or blending stick to complete / refine the effect.

The very first step to working with shading is to have the child look carefully. What is

light? What is dark? Look in the center. Look at the shadow a figure is casting. One will see different degrees of dark and light in the shadow itself. The core, or center of the shadow, will look darker than the periphery of the shadow. Have the child look around at other shadows that are cast to help them see the gradation in shadow. Once the child has examined the shape, attempt to draw it on paper along with the children.

Begin by drawing a circle. Establish where light is coming from to understand where shadows are falling. One can mark off where the shading begins by drawing an arc across the circumference. The shadow of the object will probably be an oval of sorts – with the center being relatively darker than the periphery of the shadow. The interesting thing about looking at a sphere is that there is a large light section, then the shaded area which is graded light to dark from the first large lighted area – but then is followed by another arc enclosing a third area where there is again a lightening of the shade from reflected light – the third area being relatively more narrow than the first two areas.

The Human Body

It is important when you take up drawing the human body that one considers movement of the human body. Initially, the children can strike different poses, doing 30 second sketches. Get the lines and basic flow of the shapes – 15 to 30 second sketches. It is good to have a mannequin of the human body in the classroom; there are also mannequins available of animals. Have the child look at it and point out to them that the body parts are just geometrical shapes. The head is not a circle, but an oval. The thoracic cavity is kind of an ovoid. Be sure to point out the joints; neck, shoulder joint, wrists, shoulders – otherwise a drawing will look static, incapable of movement.

Give the child newsprint and a piece of charcoal. Take them step by step through the different body parts, drawing it each time on the newsprint. They will not necessarily want to keep the newsprint but sometimes it does turn out nice. The main goal, however, is that they begin to feel comfortable drawing the entire body. Put the mannequin in different poses or have the children pose for each other (as long as they can maintain the pose for the time required).

Another exercise is to get large pieces of butcher paper and do life-size drawings of the human body. From their own work in relation to the mannequin or model, make them aware of the proportions among the different body-parts (e.g. the head is not larger than the chest).

The Face

Have the child make a portrait of himself. Save it year-to-year for the child to see his progression in art as well as the progression in how he sees himself. The child should realize there are mathematical proportions to the face. If you give him a piece of paper and ask him to draw a face, they might draw a simple stick-figure level drawing. After the lesson, they are surprised to find the head is not a circle but an oval. Have them examine a series of face-shapes since they naturally vary.

Get a rule and look to see where the eyes are on the head. If one looks carefully, he sees the eyes fall about half way between the top and bottom of the head. So draw a line across the head at that point. Now cut the bottom half into half again – into fourths. The line between the bottom two fourths is where the tip of the nose appears. Then, if you take half of the bottom fourth again, this is where the mouth will fall.

With the eyes, there is a width of about 5 eyelids from one side to the other. They eyes are also ovals – and they appear in the second and fourth position horizontally on the face. There remains room for an eyelid between the eyes and on the two sides. The iris takes up most of the eye within each oval. Add the small pupils in the centers of the irises.

The nose begins from the eyes and goes down to where the tip appears. Nostrils are not necessarily symmetrical. Eyebrows continue the line of the nose above the eyes. Width of the nose varies by person.

Draw perpendicular lines from the pupils downward and this generally marks the limit of the lips on either side.

Finally, the tops of the ears are usually even with the eyes. The ears generally go down to or close to the upper lip. The neck proceeds down from the ears and have enough width to imply enough muscle to hold the head up.

After drawing the face, the children begin to look more closely at faces they see. Have a mirror in the classroom. Use a large piece of good quality paper of any color and allow the child to make a self-portrait using pastels; encourage the child to fill up the page.

Encouragement

If a child is critical and wants to stop – encourage and encourage the child to continue. Let them know there is no wrong way. Encourage them to look at other artists, those less literal and allow them to copy art from other artists. Picasso learned by copying other artists. The bottom line is make sure they have fun drawing. If they want to sketch in the classroom, that is a legitimate occupation. Allow them to sketch while reading aloud. They might each have their own sketchbook.

Epilogue

The book, “The Complete Drawing Course”, in a good classroom reference for shading. Children can draw with wire as well – bending it into lines and shapes. See artist Alexander Calder for examples of this type of work.

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Print-Making

The children have probably come to the elementary classroom with experience with print-making in the primary class. They may have made potato prints or orange prints – perhaps sponge prints.

A printing ink is better than paint for print-making. It cleans up easily and is water-soluble. Use special paper for print-making. Begin with preliminary activities in the classroom.

Gather some Styrofoam plates from restaurants, cut out shapes from them and glue those onto a piece of cardboard – for example. Ink the raised shapes of the Styrofoam and then press the image onto a piece of paper. So one does not need lots of expensive materials for print-making.

If you can afford more materials, especially in the 9-12 class, introduce formal print-making to the children. Have the child make the picture of what he wants to make a print of. Then, he can draw onto the Softoleum, the image he has created. Before doing this, check the composition, the kinds of lines and so on. Each line he cuts out will be something that doesn't take a color. So, if the child has drawn a daisy and he wants to have the center parts, he will need to leave lines there to avoid having a large empty space.

Once the child is happy with the image, show the child how to cut the Softoleum away from the body. The tool is sharp and must be respected. Have them experiment in the beginning for experience with what hand-tension is required; they can go right to the bottom easily. If they don't cut a deep enough groove the first time and have printed – this is okay. Print-makers do this as well – as a draft print. The print can be cut more as needed. The raised surfaces they have will be where they apply the color.

Have the child begin by putting a small drop or two of ink in the tray. Use the brayer to get it covered with ink, equally on across its surface. Then have the child take the baren, lay the paper on the Softoleum, and run the baren over the paper, over and over, to apply the ink from the Softoleum. Pick up the paper and see what you ended up with. If you want a different color, choose another.

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Clay

Clay is one of the nicest media to work with; it is forgiving. Get pieces of plywood, 12 inches square at the smallest. Cover them with muslin – a type of cloth – and this is a good working surface for clay work.

One needs to learn how to wedge clay. Some of the 25 pound bags bought in the store is pre-wedged. There is a difference between wedging and kneading. Kneading is pushing air into the material. Wedging is an effort to get all the air out of the material – since in the oven, a hot air bubble will explode.

Cut a piece of clay off with wire. The first time the child works with clay, just let them feel it, squeeze. Make a shape and they crush it and begin again – over and over. When ready to make a figure for keeps there are two ways to proceed. Add pieces to another figure – called the additive process. Or, one can take clay away from an existing piece – the more difficult technique.

If adding clay, tell about scoring. The area on the arm that will be attached will be scored as well as the area to which the arm is attached is also scored. Put 'slip', water and clay mixed between the surfaces and then attached the two scored surfaces. They will affix more readily when both surfaces are equally wet.

When creating a sculpture, one has to scoop out the center since clay is very heavy. For example, making a figure, scoop out the center of the figure to make it lighter and remove air bubbles; in a certain state of dryness, it will not collapse. Don't dry it too fast or the clay will crack. If you use a dry-cleaner plastic to cover the clay, it will dry out very slowly – exposing it to air little by little – over a week or more. When it is completely dry, then it can be baked in the kiln. Too soon, and it will explode in the kiln. Usually the color of the clay will indicate it is dry.

Sometimes one has to make armature -an internal surface to establish support for a shape - to build up a shape. Crushed newspaper can be used for this. After the clay dries, it will support its own weight and it can then be removed.

Firing

After baking the clay in the kiln, the piece is called a bisque. Now you can glaze it. One sees the color in the bottle but this is not the color it will take after baking. Alternatively, one can paint the clay with acrylic or other paint. Dishes cannot be painted since one cannot eat the acrylic.

Take a ball of clay and pinch the side of it to gradually form a shape. Push a leaf or some other object into the clay for texture.

To make a coil-pot, take clay and roll it until you have a big long snake. Then coil it up from the bottom. As one builds up the walls, layer the clay on top of each successive coil; score and slip between each layer of the coil. If you don't like the coil effect on the outside, use some water and an instrument of some kind to smooth it out.

Then you could roll out flat things like pie dough, ¼ inch thick. Cut a rectangle for the bottom. Cut two more rectangles for the sides, scoring and slipping as one attaches each piece. Measure sides and ends, squeezing or scrunching edges to make the perfect fit.

Tiles are also neat to make. Make a flat piece, cut out a shape and add designs to make a 'relief', such as what one sees on the Parthenon. A relief can typically attach to a wall.

Make masks. Use plaster gauze, rolls of it from art stores. This is like the gauze casts are made from. Cut it into small sections of varying sizes. Prepare the face it will go upon; that face has to be someone who wants to do it since it can be a bit scary. To prepare that child, after speaking to him psychologically about the fear, prepare him by giving him a shower cap for the hair, the spread Vaseline on the neck, ears and so forth – especially on eyebrows. Put a smock on this child and lay him on the floor. Start by dipping the plaster-covered gauze into the water and lay the gauze across the face – don't close up both nose and mouth! Sometimes they don't like eyes covered. Gently press the gauze down layer by layer onto the face. Build up enough so there is an armature for the gauze. It dries quickly and comes off easily if Vaseline has been applied. When it dry and pretty solid, you can build up features further, optionally. Once the form is complete, you can gesso it to make the surface less absorbent. Then you can paint the mask using acrylics with designs or not. One can then hang it on a wall or other display.

Epilogue

Other activities could be paper-making, weaving, embroidery – all are good activities. Again, make sure they consider composition and basic art principles as they do this work as well.

Appendix